THE ROYAL ALBERT HALL

Tackling current challenges and exploring future revenue streams

Assessment 1: 2,490 words

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Introduction

Initially known as "Albertopolis" after Prince Albert, the site was part of the Great Exhibition of 1851, which attracted over six million visitors and created profit equivalent to £26.5 million. After Prince Albert's death in 1861, Sir Henry Cole pushed to build The Royal Albert Hall (RAH). The venue was then opened by Queen Victoria in 1871[1].

Recent events in the UK have created challenges for the entertainment industry. The COVID-19 pandemic, for example, caused the halls' doors to close in March 2020 for the first time since World War II, leading to a loss of 96% of its profits overnight and around £30 million by December 2020.[1]

This report seeks to investigate the RAH's current management strategy. A situation analysis will first be conducted using **Porter's Five Competitive Forces Framework**[2] and a **SWOT analysis**[3]. Subsequently, approaches to boost income will be considered, one aligning with the '**Red Ocean' Strategy**[4], and the other with the '**Blue Ocean' Strategy**[4]. Finally, intricate details on customer segmentation and promotion will be elaborated, before concluding with a '**Force Field Analysis'**[5].

Section 1: Situation Analysis

Porter's Five Forces

Porter's Five Forces[2] assesses the competitiveness of an industry and its profit-making potential using forces ranked from 1 (weak) to 5 (strong). The model identifies power within a sector and helps improving managing strategies.

Force	**Ranking**
Competitive Rivalry	4
Power of Supplier	3
Power of Buyers	5
Threat of Entry	1
Threat of Substitution	3

Competitive Rivalry

Although the RAH cannot be directly compared to its rivalry due to its variety of events[19] and historical value, its competitors include entertainment arenas (e.g. Wembley Stadium, O2 Arena) – which host concerts, fashion shows and product launches[6]; other Grade I listed performing arts venues (e.g. Theatre Royal Drury Lane[57], the Royal Opera House[58]) for musicals; sport venues (e.g. Wimbledon, Emirates Stadium[7]); and educational institutions (e.g. UCL) for ceremonies/conferences. Many of its competitors are either larger in capacity, or more specialized in the type of event they host, thus giving them power and taking away market share.

Power of Suppliers

The RAH's supplier include the entertainers/performers, food and beverage companies (e.g. Coca-Cola for soft drinks, Bacardi for spirits)[8], ticket selling platforms (e.g. Viagogo, Ticketmaster). This force is median: it can be considered high for performers, as some may attract larger audiences thus easily raising their prices; but low for victuals, as they could be replaced (e.g. Pepsi replacing Coca-Cola, and other food choices).

Power of Buyers

The RAH's power of customers lies within the artists and agencies (buyers) who rent the venue but also within the audience (customers), which varies depending on the type of entertainment, time of the year, arena capacity, facilities, and location. The RAH has an advantage for being in central London, but its rivalry offers similar services. These factors, along with the fact that there

are no switching costs for customers, make it easy for them to switch to competitors based on their show preferences or ticket costs.[9]

Threat of Entry

As of January 2024, the Madison Square Garden Entertainment Company were planning on launching a Sphere in Stratford, near the Olympic Park. This was expected to have a main auditorium hosting 21,500 guests, a smaller music venue and a nightclub[10], but was recently ruled-out. Administrative issues such as licensing[47], intellectual property[48], high building[49] and registration[50] costs, along with the high competitiveness of the industry, inexistence of other projects and the RAH's cultural power lower this threat.

Threat of Substitution

Customers can fulfill their need of live entertainment in other ways. For instance, the Cirque du Soleil shows can be viewed on their "60 Minute Special" YouTube clips which offer 1.1 million subscribers a cheaper alternative to live entertainment[11]. Artist like Ed Sheeran who previously performed at the RAH can be streamed on Apple Live Music[12] for £10.99 instead of buying £50-150 RAH tickets[13][14]. In fact, digital communication usage rose from 50% to 84% after the pandemic[15]. Other forms of entertainment, such as cinemas, nightclubs, traveling, reading[51], etc. can also be substitutes for live entertainment, thus increasing this threat.

Overall, seeing that the competition and power of customers are high, the live entertainment industry can be considered as attractive for existing organizations[52] (concerts attracted 4.9 million people in London in 2022[16]). However, this, along with the high threat of substitution, suggest that it is not optimal for new organizations to enter the industry.

SWOT Analysis

Strength	Weaknesses
o Historical value - part of the 2.5% of Grade I listed buildings in UK)[17] o Global reputation and branding in the UK[18] o Located in central London, near other important institutions (e.g. Imperial College). o Diversification of entertainment (e.g. films in festivals, concerts, conferences)[44].	o RAH structure: power and funds limited by Members and Trustees[19]. o Arena capacity which varies for exclusive vs ordinary shows[19]. o High staff and building maintenance cost[19]. o Sound systems (e.g. Elgar room not acoustically separated from main auditorium)[19]. o Low ratio of produced to presented shows[19]. o Scheduling and balancing commercial vs educational entertainment[19]. o Building cannot be easily modified due to Grade 1 listing[17].
Opportunities	**Threats**
o Integration of technology to increase profits[19]. o Creating more educational programs like "Dance for Parkinson's"[19] to increase inclusivity. o Collaboration with other organizations (e.g. Donne Foundation)[45] to increase awareness of RAH. o Implementing efforts towards sustainability[20], which can attract a new customer segment (90% of Londoners care about climate change)[53].	o Change of consumer interest/habits: 98% of Gen Z own smartphones (substitute for live entertainment)[21] o Intense competition, as mentioned in Porter's Five Forces. o Financial instability (no government funding, high dependence on fundraising)[19]. o Balancing new technology and building listing/reputation[19].

The top three findings which could harm the future of the RAH:

	Finding	**Potential harm**	**How to manage it**
1	Organizational structure of RAH	Reducing profit-making opportunities	• Renegotiate norms: increasing ratio of produced to presented shows[19]. • Increasing ratio of exclusive to ordinary shows[19]
2	Change of consumer interests/habits	Losing customers (audience) and buyers (performers)	• Focus on event and marketing versatility (e.g. heavily target Gen Z on TikTok by following viral trends). • Increase associate artists who can promote the RAH (like Anna Lapwood, with big fanbase on TikTok)[19].
3	Adapting to new technology	Decrease in quality of performance (sound, lights, visuals)	• Invest in technology to deliver better customer experience than competitors (e.g. new sound systems that can cover larger areas of the arena, leading to the ability of adding more seating area and thus higher profits)[19].

Section 2: Exploring Ideas for Increasing Revenues

This section aims to discuss two ideas which will increase revenue for the RAH. The first follows a "**Red Ocean Strategy**", whose aim is to beat competitors in an existing market space[4].

Following the 5 Red Ocean principles, the first idea is to eliminate or reduce smaller events to create RAH-produced interactive shows, which require the customers in the existing market space to engage with performers and decide the series of events of the story. This idea could be applied to a variety of shows, thus reaching diverse audiences (e.g. children, students, adults…). It can be

done by distributing audience response systems or through a platform on their phones (e.g. Mentimeter or creating a RAH app), thus allowing them to pick between several outcomes throughout intervals in the show. This idea is based on Netflix's interactive specials[22], but brought to life. This would help the RAH tackle findings (2) and (3) mentioned in Section 1, as it would push them to adapt to change of customer habits and technological developments.

This beats the competition as most interactive experiences in London require physical movement (e.g. escape rooms, Life Size Monopoly), or are simply lights/visual effects-based shows (e.g. Outernet)[23]. Furthermore, the RAH's capacity is much smaller than its arena competitors (5,000 vs the O2 which has 20,000)[24], thus making such experiences easier to manage. The combination of immersive experiences and preforming arts is not done anywhere, and the idea of maximizing the audience's personal engagement[25] allows the RAH differentiation in a strategic way.

Another aspect is to exploit existing demand: there has been an increase of 375% of fundings for the entertainment sector between 2020 and 2022[26], indicating that the implementation of such technology in the RAH could attract more investors. The last aim is to make a value-cost trade off: bulk buying audience response systems doesn't require a lot of capital (range of £15,000[27]), and an online voting system could be done through the RAH's website, therefore lowering costs.

The second idea follows a "**Blue Ocean Strategy**", who's aim is to create an uncontested market and eliminate the competition[4].

Following the 5 Blue Ocean principles, the idea is to create a collaboration with LEGO®[28]. Such prototype of the RAH was already built using 4,000 blocks by the resident classical music expert Barney Rayfield back in 2020[29]. In fact, this idea was also suggested on the official LEGO® website, comparing it to other sets such as the Sydney Opera House[30]. This would allow the RAH to create uncontested market space, which has been proven to exist seeing that sets of other famous monuments such as the Taj Mahal[31] or the Red London Telephone Box[32] are currently being sold for around £100.

In addition, competitors become irrelevant as they don't possess the same architectural and historical value worth replicating on LEGO®. This also aligns with the pursuit of differentiation seeing that none of the competitors have an existing LEGO® set. In terms of creating and capturing demand, the idea has the potential to attract people in all three tiers of non-customers, i.e. from "soon-to-be customers" to people who have never considered attending the RAH[33], as adding additional information on the Lego construction booklet about the history of the RAH could raise awareness of its existence and purposes. This idea would break the value-cost trade off, as elaborated in the table below:

Eliminate	**Raise**
○ Issues related to structure of RAH ○ Commuting to RAH ○ Building renovation requirements	○ Use of architectural and cultural power ○ Use of global reputation ○ Profits (useful for maintenance, equipment, staff) ○ Presence on national and international scale
Reduce	**Create**
○ Scheduling problems ○ Issues related to change of consumer interest ○ Need of new technology	○ New perspective of RAH (as a toy) ○ Younger generation interest ○ Awareness of RAH ○ New product in RAH gift shop, new merchandise.

Section 3a: Customer Segmentation

This next section seeks to develop a customer segment using the four segmentation variables[34] for the Lego idea. Overall, the set could target a large audience - children, university students and young adults - aged between 0 and 29, and making up 39.4% of Greater London's population[36] (approximately 3.5 million people[46]).

1- Demographic

LEGOs are known to be highly appreciated by children aged between 1 to 15 (first target audience)– it was voted best toy company in the world in 2023[35]. The second target audience (focus of this report) is high school and university students. In 2021, approximately 86,000 students majored in history, 62,000 in architecture, 184,000 in engineering in the UK[54]. The RAH is a historical monument and not targeted to a specific gender, religion, or ethnicity. The set can educate people about history (e.g. Great Exhibition,) and can be sold for around £100, thus accessible to numerous financial backgrounds.

2- Geographic

There are more than 40 universities in the London alone[37], and 166 in the UK[38], in cities such as Edinburgh, Manchester, etc. Then, there are 20,806 primary schools and 4,190 secondary schools in the UK[55], indicating the segment is very large on a regional and national scale. The advantage of this idea is that it can easily be sold online, reaching a much larger audience: on an international scale, as of 2023, 235 million students are enrolled in a university[56].

3- Behavioral

The set can be bought on occasions (Christmas, birthdays), or for leisure. It can attract collectors, students who like hands-on activities, students interested learning about the hall (via the booklet), thus raising awareness on the presence of the hall and attracting the RAH's non-customers. LEGO's have a high frequency of usage (can be built/dismantled as many times as wanted), which can be considered as an advantage.

4- Psychographic

The younger people in this segment would be attracted to this idea of building LEGOs in their free time (e.g. after school activity, during summer holidays). University students and young adults

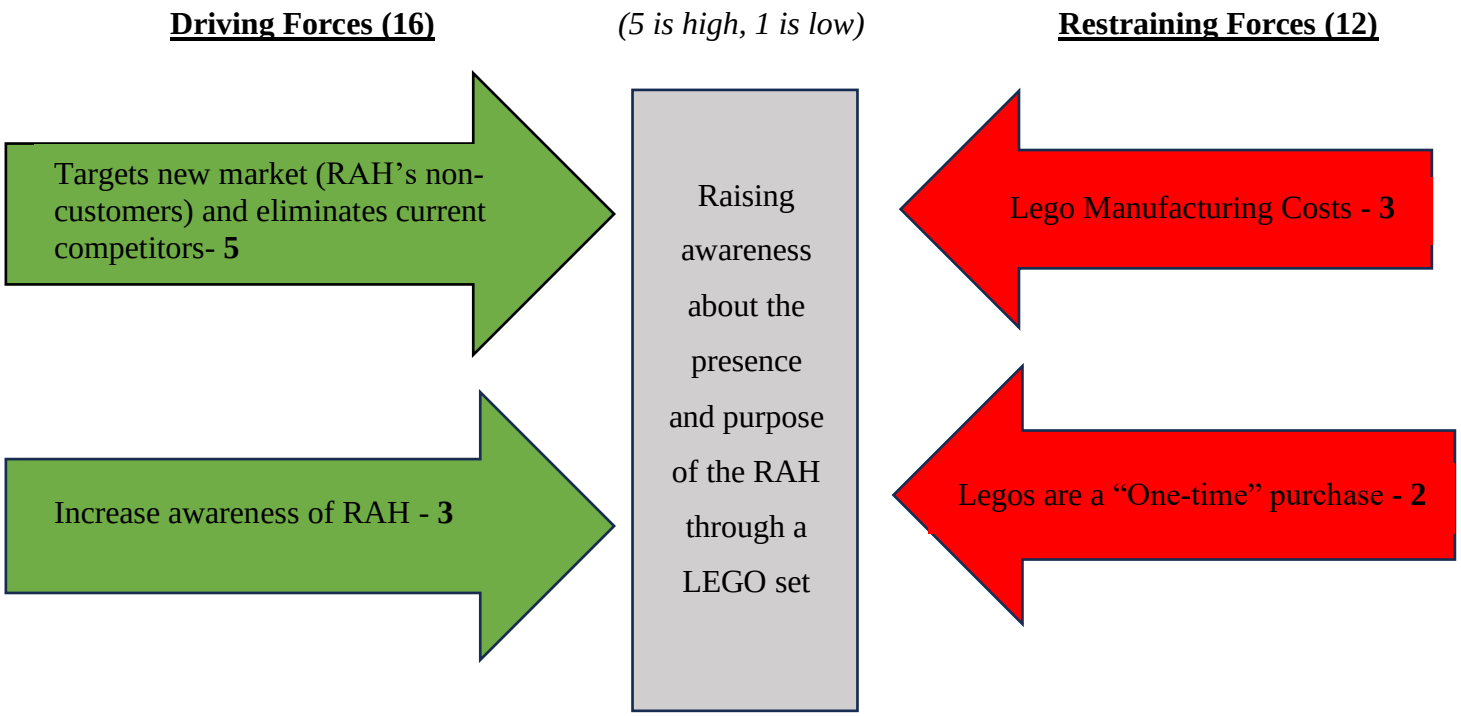
would be attracted to the complexity of the set (4,000 pieces), as well as the knowledge they gain from the booklet. The segment would target people who enjoy solving problems, building things, and are imaginative. For adults, LEGOs can serve as a stress/anxiety relief[39].

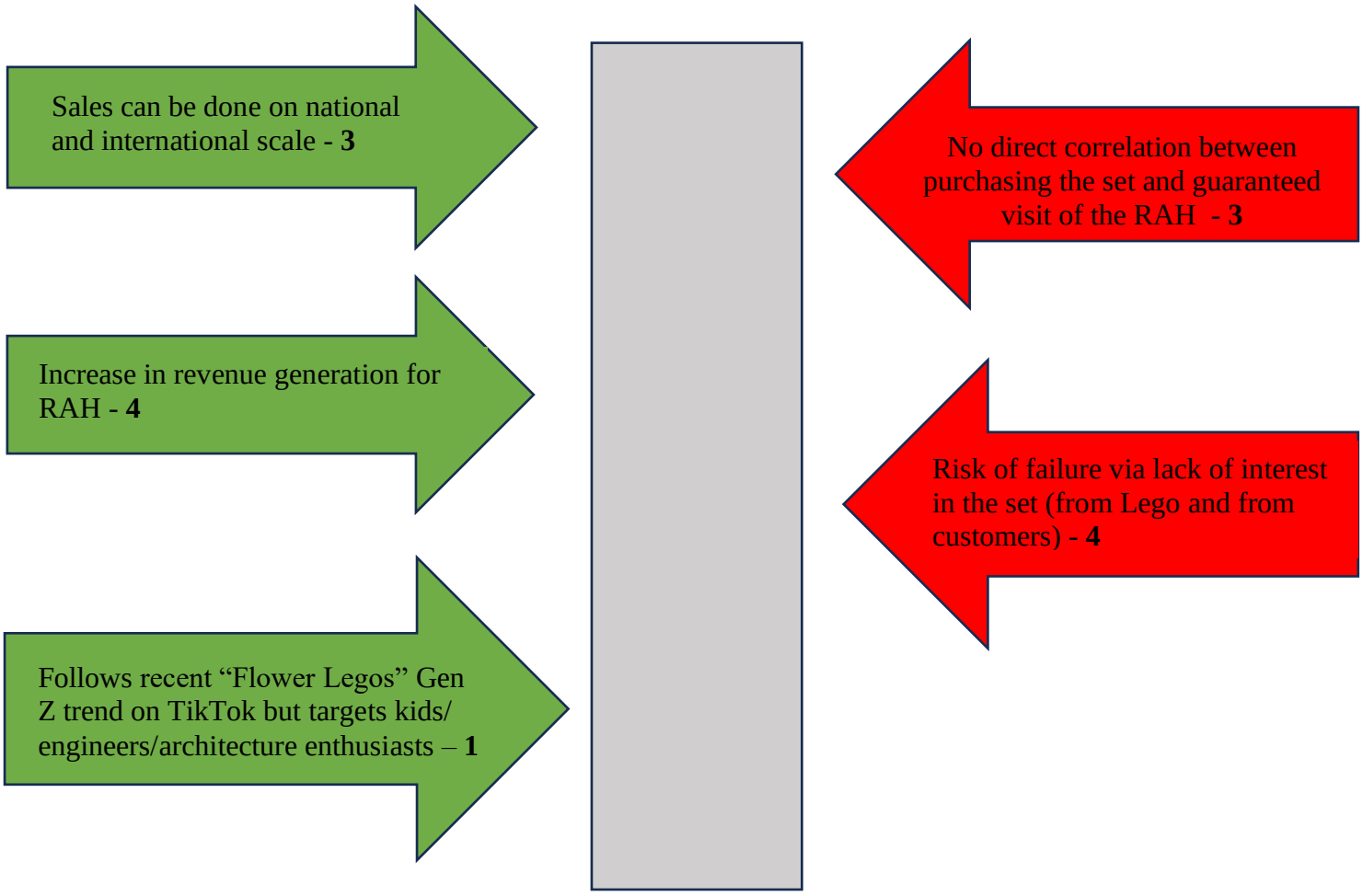
Section 3b: Marketing

Targetting this segment - mostly made up of Gen Z (i.e. people between the ages of 11 to 26[40]) - can be done by following the "Promotion" aspect from the Marketing Mix[34]. To generate interest and awareness, ads can be done through Gen Z's most used social platforms: Youtube (80%), Instagram (75%) and TikTok (69%)[41]. For Youtube, an ad costs around $0.10 to $0.30 per view[42]. The final budget depends the RAH's desired number of views. To generate action, adding links to the online lego or RAH store would work. Other ways to promote this set can include displaying it in toy stores (e.g Hamleys) and schools.

Conclusion

The final aspect that should be discussed is the "Force Field Analysis"[43], which lists and ranks the driving and restraining forces of the previously-discussed LEGO idea.





To conclude, seeing that this idea's driving forces amount to 16 vs. 12 for the restraining forces, it can be deemed as a useful way to increase revenue for the RAH.

Referring to the situation/SWOT analysis, it uses its architectural and historical strength as a reason for recreating it on LEGOs and teaching about it on a construction booklet. It also uses its strength in global reputation to target audiences on an international scale (e.g. online stores). Finally, the idea tackles the limitations of entertainment-based profit due to the organizational structure of the RAH as it doesn't involve the members' seat allocations; it attempts to follow booming trends on TikTok thus adapting to the change in consumer habits; and eliminates current intense competition by entering a new industry.

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